



Rutting

For most of the year, red deer stags remain apart from the females, or hinds, and their young. During the breeding season, known as the rut, males collect harems of hinds which they vigorously defend by roaring or, if necessary, by fighting.

Breeding

Most species of antelope and deer give birth when the weather is fine and food is abundant. Young caribou are born in early June when the herd is migrating. The calves can follow their mother within minutes of birth. The young of some species are left alone. Their mothers come to suckle and clean them several times a day, until they are strong enough to join the herd.

Caribou

The Eurasian reindeer and the North American caribou are the same species. They live in large herds and migrate long distances every year to find food. The reindeer has been semi-domesticated by, among others, the Lapps of north Europe.



Female reindeer are the only female deer that grow antlers.

Females in a herd give birth within two weeks of each other.

A calf can run with the herd when only an hour old.

A reindeer calf weighs about 4 kg (9 lb) at birth.

Reindeer with calf

Antelope habitats

Antelopes are found in most kinds of tropical and subtropical habitats. Most are creatures of the open plains and forests, but others have adapted to live in deserts, wetlands, and mountains. Grazing antelopes live where there is plenty of grass, whereas the browsers tend to inhabit woodlands and forests.



Woodland inhabitant

Also called the chousingha, the shy, solitary four-horned antelope lives in wooded, hilly country. Hunting has greatly reduced its numbers, but it still survives in several wildlife reserves in India, and one reserve in Nepal.



Sitatunga hoof

Swamp inhabitant

The sitatunga lives only in swamps and marshes. It has evolved long hooves that help it to walk on marshy ground. When danger threatens, it submerges itself in water leaving only its nostrils exposed.



Pointed antler

Muntjak head

Tusk-like teeth

Muntjak skull

Defence

Some deer and antelope, the larger species in particular, may sometimes use their antlers and horns to defend themselves, although generally antlers and horns are not strong enough for defence. Most deer and antelopes rely on their excellent eyesight and acute sense of hearing to detect potential enemies, and on speed to escape from any predators that attack.

Self-defence

If attacked, a muntjak's first defence is to run away. If this fails, males thrash with their antlers. These are mounted on "stalks" of bone as long as the antlers themselves. Males also have two tusk-like teeth used mainly in fighting rivals.



Camouflage

Some deer and antelope avoid predators because they blend into their surroundings. Kirk's dik-dik is an African antelope that lives in dry bush country, where the thorny thickets protect it.

Pronking

The springbok of Africa can run fast to escape a predator. Like most gazelles, it will often leap high into the air, with legs stiff, hooves close together, and back arched. Called pronking, or stotting, this action may confuse predators, raise the alarm, or simply give the gazelle a better view.

RED DEER

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Cervus elaphus*

ORDER Artiodactyla

FAMILY Cervidae

DISTRIBUTION Europe and Asia.
Introduced into Australia, New Zealand, and South America

HABITAT Woodland and open country

DIET Grass, leaves, shoots, flowers (it both grazes and browses)

SIZE Height at the shoulder: 1.4 m
(4 ft 6 in)

LIFESPAN 12–15 years

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